Veterans of Foreign Wars: 2024 Telehealth Experience Survey Report

Prepared by: VFW National Veterans Service **Survey Period:** April - June 2024 **Respondents:** 3,247 VFW members who used VA telehealth services **Report Date:** August 2024

Executive Summary

The Veterans of Foreign Wars conducted a comprehensive survey of members' experiences with VA telehealth services to inform our advocacy priorities and provide actionable feedback to VA leadership. This report presents key findings and recommendations based on responses from over 3,200 Veterans across all 50 states.

Key Takeaways:

- 78% of respondents value telehealth and want to continue using it
- 61% experienced technical difficulties at least once
- 44% needed help from family member or caregiver to connect
- 89% want easier ways to test their setup before appointments
- Veterans over 70 report 2x more technical challenges than younger Veterans

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Methodology

Survey Distribution

- Email invitation to all VFW members with email on file
- Promoted through VFW Magazine and social media
- Paper surveys available at VFW posts by request

Respondent Demographics

Characteristic	Percentage
Age	
Under 50	12%
50-64	28%
65-74	34%
75+	26%
Service Era	
Vietnam	38%

Characteristic	Percentage
Gulf War	29%
Post-9/11	24%
Other	9%
Location	
Urban	41%
Suburban	32%
Rural	27%
Internet Access	
Home broadband	72%
Mobile data only	18%
Limited/unreliable	10%

Key Findings

Finding 1: Strong Support for Telehealth, Despite Challenges

78% of respondents said they want to continue using telehealth for appropriate appointments.

Top reasons for telehealth preference:

1. "Don't have to drive to VA facility" (67%)
2. "Can attend from comfort of home" (54%)
3. "Saves time overall" (49%)
4. "Easier to fit into my schedule" (41%)
5. "Health conditions make travel difficult" (38%)

> "At 82 years old, I shouldn't have to drive 90 minutes each way just for a 15-minute check-up. Video visits have been a blessing when they work." — Army Veteran, Rural Montana

Finding 2: Technical Difficulties Remain Pervasive

61% of respondents experienced technical difficulties with at least one telehealth appointment.

Most common issues reported:

Issue	Percentage
Audio problems (can't hear or be heard)	47%
Video not working	38%
Couldn't figure out how to join	34%
Got kicked out of appointment	28%
Link didn't work	24%
Long wait time in "virtual waiting room"	21%

> "I'm a combat veteran. I've faced enemy fire. But trying to get my camera to work for a doctor's appointment makes me want to give up." — Marine Veteran, Florida

Finding 3: Significant Reliance on Caregiver Support

44% of respondents said they needed help from a family member, caregiver, or friend to connect to their telehealth appointment.

Among respondents age 75+, this number rises to **68%**.

Types of help needed:

- Setting up device/camera (52%)
- Clicking the right link to join (47%)
- Troubleshooting when something went wrong (61%)
- Staying in the appointment (adjusting settings, etc.) (29%)

> "My daughter has to come over every time I have a video appointment. She shouldn't have to take off work just to help me click a button." — Navy Veteran, Ohio

Finding 4: Pre-Appointment Preparation is Inadequate

Only 34% of respondents said they received clear instructions on how to prepare for their telehealth appointment.

89% said they would use a tool to test their setup before appointments if it were easy to find.

Respondents who tested their setup beforehand (through any means) were **3x more likely** to rate their telehealth experience as "excellent."

Finding 5: Significant Age-Based Disparities

Veterans over 70 reported **2x more technical challenges** than Veterans under 60.

Experience	Under 60	60-70	Over 70
Joined without difficulty	71%	54%	38%
Needed help to connect	22%	41%	68%
Missed appointment due to tech	8%	14%	27%
Would prefer in-person instead	18%	29%	44%

Finding 6: Rural Veterans Face Compounded Challenges

Rural Veterans reported:

- Lower internet reliability (34% reported issues vs. 12% urban)
- Fewer options for in-person technical help
- Greater appreciation for telehealth (82% support vs. 74% urban)
- More frustration when technical issues occur

> "Out here, the nearest VA is 3 hours away. Telehealth is my only realistic option. When it doesn't work, I just don't get care that week." — Army Veteran, Rural Nevada

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Veteran Voices: What Would Help Most

We asked respondents: "What one change would most improve your telehealth experience?"

Top responses (in their words):

1. **"Make it simpler to join"** (mentioned by 41%)
   - "One button, that's it"
   - "Stop making me log in three different places"
   - "Just send me a link that works"
2. **"Let me test before my appointment"** (mentioned by 34%)
   - "I want to know my camera works before I'm supposed to see my doctor"
   - "Send me a reminder the day before with a test link"
3. **"Better help when things go wrong"** (mentioned by 28%)
   - "A real person to call, not a robot"
   - "Someone who can see what I'm seeing and help me fix it"
   - "Don't make me start over from scratch"
4. **"Remember my settings"** (mentioned by 22%)
   - "Why do I have to allow my camera every single time?"

- "My phone should just know how to do this by now"

5. "**More patience from providers**" (mentioned by 15%)
   - "Don't start the clock until I'm actually connected"
   - "Understand that this is hard for some of us"

VFW Recommendations to VA

Based on survey findings, VFW respectfully urges VA to prioritize the following actions:

Recommendation 1: Implement Universal Pre-Appointment Testing

Automatically send all Veterans a device/connection test link 24-48 hours before their telehealth appointment. For Veterans who fail the test, proactively reach out with support or rescheduling options.

Recommendation 2: Create One-Click Joining

Reduce the joining process to a single click from the appointment reminder. Eliminate duplicate logins and unnecessary confirmation screens.

Recommendation 3: Establish Dedicated Telehealth Technical Support Line

Create a phone number Veterans can call specifically for telehealth technical issues, staffed by patient representatives trained in common troubleshooting scenarios. Hours should extend beyond standard business hours.

Recommendation 4: Develop Caregiver-Friendly Features

Recognize that many Veterans rely on caregivers for telehealth access. Create features that allow caregivers to help set up appointments while maintaining Veteran privacy for the clinical conversation.

Recommendation 5: Invest in Digital Literacy Outreach

Partner with VSOs, community organizations, and VA facilities to offer in-person telehealth training sessions. Provide take-home materials and ongoing support.

Recommendation 6: Prioritize Accessibility

Ensure telehealth platforms meet the needs of Veterans with visual, hearing, cognitive, and motor impairments. Involve disabled Veterans in testing and design.

Conclusion

VA telehealth services have the potential to dramatically improve access to care for Veterans, particularly those in rural areas or with mobility limitations. However, current technical barriers prevent many Veterans—especially older Veterans—from fully benefiting from these services.

VFW stands ready to partner with VA in addressing these challenges. Our members want telehealth to succeed. With targeted investments in simplicity, support, and accessibility, VA can deliver on the promise of convenient,

high-quality virtual care for all Veterans.

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Appendix: Full survey instrument and raw data available upon request.